Photos: DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



CASE STUDY

MAHIDUL ISLAM, 34
Murshidabad

Educational qualification: MA in Political Science and BEd

Merit list rank: 55

Applied for teacher's position in Class XI and XII

Current status: Earns nothing

Mahidul, a father of two, used to be a private tutor. But for the past three years, he has been agitating against the alleged irregularities in the recruitment of teachers. In spearheading the protest, he has lost his students and income. "I have mortgaged my wife's jewellery to keep us going for the next few months. If I don't get a job, I will have no option but to take a drastic step. I am not keeping well and doctors say if I don't go for treatment, the ailment might take a turn for the worse," he says.



CASE STUDY

LAKSHMI MONDAL, 33
Hooghly

Educational qualification: Post graduate in philosophy

Merit list rank: 82

Applied for position in Class XI, XII

Current status: Earns Rs 2,000 a month as a private tutor

Coming from a poor family, Lakshmi fled home to do her MA as her parents wanted to marry her off. With first division marks, she was confident of securing a job. Despite a reasonably high rank in the SLST, she is yet to get an appointment letter. Lakshmi's father is frail and earns a little by weaving fishing nets; her mother makes a meagre living as a caregiver. Lakshmi says if she gets the teaching job, she'll ask her mother to stop working and get medical treatment for her father.

led to a mad scramble. So much so that many sold off land to organise the bribe money. "The revenue department's earnings from land sale over the past decade has been over Rs 1,000 crore," alleges a person associated with the land revenue office in Birbhum.

Former TMC minister U.N. Biswas, also an ex-CBI director, confirms the existence of the racket on the ground. In 2016, when he was the minister for backward classes welfare, a retired army officer tipped him off on government jobs being on sale. "I found that in my constituency one person was running this racket. I asked many youths to lodge a police complaint, but they were reluctant. They claimed the person refunded the money with interest if he failed to secure a job," says Biswas.

Says a candidate who was approached by agents before the SLST: "Those who paid up and struck a deal with the agents were told before the test to just write their names and roll numbers and submit blank answer sheets. It made identification and manipulation easier. If a candidate approached agents after the test, they had to pay extra as correction of answer scripts by fetching OMR (optical mark recognition) sheets and uploading corrected answer sheets needed extra effort. Some agents took money to supply answers inside the examination hall through mobile phones. Candidates are required to send a picture of their OMR sheet series."

SOME AGENTS TOOK MONEY TO SUPPLY CORRECT ANSWERS INSIDE THE EXAMINATION HALL THROUGH MOBILE PHONES

The 68-page report of the Justice Bag panel revealed how some unsuccessful candidates misused the RTI Act for applications to fetch answer scripts. People in the education department then uploaded the OMR sheets with higher scores. The five-member panel issued appointment letters for these candidates. Though the report made the observations about the recruitment of Group C and D staff, the same process, it is known, was used to hire teachers too. "A friend of mine told us that after failing the written test, he still got a job. He said he had demanded a review through the RTI Act, which gave him pass marks, after which he was appointed in less than 24 hours," says Sudip Mondal of Yuva-Chhatra Ekta Mancha, a union of successful candidates formed to fight the legal battle.

The ED is now probing if the money recovered from Arpita's flats has links to the alleged scam, though both Arpita and Chatterjee have claimed they are "victims of a conspiracy". While the court will decide the next course of action, the candidates have lost crucial years and are still waiting for jobs. Their only demand now is that justice takes a faster path, and the appointment letters reach them soon. ■